

LESSON 4 · ART SCHOOL, BUT DIY

Light & Shadow

How light wraps around form and generates the shadows that make things look three-dimensional.

Overview

Value — the lightness or darkness of a mark — is what separates a flat doodle from a drawing that feels like it has weight and presence. Light describes form; shadow defines it. Once you understand how light behaves on simple geometric forms, you can apply that understanding to anything you draw, from a face to a folded cloth to a car.

The key insight of this lesson: you don't draw shadows, you draw *value zones*. Every surface in light belongs to one of roughly five zones — highlight, halftone, shadow, reflected light, and cast shadow. Learning to identify and consistently render these zones is the entire skill.

CORE CONCEPTS

The Five Value Zones

Highlight: The brightest point on the form — where light strikes most directly. Often small and sharp-edged on shiny surfaces, soft and broad on matte surfaces.

Halftone: The large mid-value area between the highlight and the shadow. This is where most of the form's color and texture lives. Often the largest zone.

Core Shadow / Terminator: The darkest part of the shadow on the form itself — the line where light no longer reaches. Not the cast shadow; the form's own shadow edge.

Reflected Light: Subtle bounce of light back into the shadow side from surrounding surfaces. Always darker than the halftone — beginners constantly make reflected light too bright, which destroys the illusion of shadow.

Cast Shadow: The shadow the form throws onto adjacent surfaces. Darkest near the contact point, softening and spreading with distance from the form.

Single Light Source Rule

Until you're advanced, work with one light source. Multiple light sources create multiple shadow sets, which is exponentially more complex to manage. Pick a direction — upper-left is traditional — and commit. Every form in your drawing responds to the same light.

The Value Scale

Build a 5- or 10-step value scale from white to black. This is your essential reference tool. Before you shade anything, identify which value zones in your scene map to which steps on your scale, then match them consistently. This eliminates guesswork and keeps drawings from getting muddy.

Local Value vs. Light

Some objects are inherently dark (a black mug) and some are inherently light (a white mug). This is **local value**. But both objects respond to the same light — the black mug still has a highlight, the white mug still has a core shadow. Light shifts local values but doesn't eliminate them. The shadow side of a white object is still lighter than the lit side of a black object.

DAILY EXERCISES

EXERCISE 1

Value Scale — The Foundation

- Create a 10-step value scale from white paper to as dark as your darkest pencil goes.
- Each step should be visually even in spacing — no big jumps or flat passages.
- Use this scale as a reference for every exercise below. Refer to it constantly.
- Redo this exercise at the start of every session until you can do it from memory.

EXERCISE 2

Sphere Shading Study

- Draw a circle. Identify a light source at upper-left.
- Locate and render all five value zones: highlight (small, soft oval), halftone (large mid-area), core shadow (curved band on the shadow side), reflected light (slightly lighter strip at the shadow's edge), cast shadow (ellipse on the ground).
- Do not blend. Build tone with parallel hatching first — then smooth if desired.
- Repeat with a cube and a cylinder. Note how the shadow edge changes from curved (sphere) to straight-edged (cube).

EXERCISE 3**Still Life Value Study**

- Set up 2–3 objects on a table under a single lamp. Turn off other lights.
- Squint at your setup until you can only see two values: light and shadow. Sketch those masses first.
- Then open your eyes and refine into 5 values using your scale.
- Limit yourself to 45 minutes. Speed teaches you what's essential.

CURATED FREE RESOURCES

Proko — Shading & Value (YouTube Channel)youtube.com/@Proko · Video Channel

Foundational breakdown of value zones, terminator line, and cast shadow. Watch the shading playlist first.

Ctrl+Paint — Light & Value Free Libraryctrlpaint.com/topics/lighting · Course

Comprehensive free library on light direction, shadow types, and value relationships.

Draw a Box — Lesson 2: Basic 3D Formsdrawabox.com/lesson/2 · Free Course

Rigorous free program for understanding how light interacts with 3D forms.

Alphonso Dunn — Tonal Values in Pen & Inkyoutube.com/@AlphonsoDunn · Video Series

Master class on building rich tonal ranges and understanding the light/shadow boundary.

Watts Atelier — Value Scale Methodyoutube.com/@WattsAtelier · Video

Professional atelier approach to the 10-step value scale — the most important foundation exercise.

New Masters Academy — Free Sample Lessonsyoutube.com/@NewMastersAcademy · Video

Classical atelier-style shading instruction using traditional academic methods.

Sinix Design — Fundamentals: Values & Lightyoutube.com/@sinixdesign · Video

Clear breakdown of value, light direction, and edge quality. One of the most efficient free treatments.

James Gurney — Light & Shadow in Paintingsyoutube.com/@JamesGurney · Video Channel

Author of Color and Light shares daily observational sketches with lighting analysis.

Mark Crilley — Realistic Shading Demosyoutube.com/@markcrilley · Video

Step-by-step shading walkthroughs for spheres, cylinders, and still-life objects.

Line of Action — Daily Form Practiceline-of-action.com · Tool

Free timed-practice tool for observational studies. Use daily alongside shading exercises.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

Every day: One shaded sphere from imagination, timed at 10 minutes. No reference. Make every value zone deliberate.

Weekly: One full still life under a single lamp. Photo your setup before and after. Compare your value rendering to the reference.